Chapter 8 — Styling React Apps

React has no built-in styling system. It renders HTML elements, and you style those with CSS — the question is only *how you write, scope and ship* that CSS. This chapter compares the approaches you will meet in real codebases, shows each one running, and helps you choose. It assumes you know CSS itself (selectors, the cascade, specificity, custom properties); if not, read the HTML & CSS book first — CSS fundamentals and modern CSS & architecture.

What you'll learn

#	Topic	You will be able to…
8.1	The styling landscape	name the five families of approaches and the problem they all try to solve
8.2	Plain CSS files	use `className`, import CSS, and avoid global name clashes with conventions
8.3	Inline styles	use the `style` prop correctly — and know its limits
8.4	CSS Modules	scope class names to a file automatically
8.5	Composing class names	build `className` from props with a `clsx`-style helper
8.6	Tailwind CSS	style with utility classes, configure a theme, avoid its traps
8.7	CSS-in-JS	understand styled-components/Emotion vs zero-runtime tools, and why the trend moved
8.8	Theming and dark mode	build light/dark/system themes with CSS variables, without a flash
8.9	Component libraries	choose between styled kits, headless libraries and copy-in components
8.10	Choosing an approach	pick a strategy for a new project

Code: `code/`. Node programs print what React puts in the DOM; the visual results are screenshots of real pages in headless Chrome (bundled with esbuild; Tailwind compiled with the Tailwind v4.3 CLI).

8.1 The styling landscape

The problem every approach solves

CSS was designed for documents: every rule is **global**, and conflicts are settled by the **cascade** (origin, specificity, order). In a large app built from hundreds of components, that causes three recurring pains:

1. **Name collisions** — two teams both write `.title`; whichever file loads last wins.
2. **Dead CSS** — nobody dares delete a rule because they can't tell which components still use it.
3. **Dynamic styles** — colours or sizes that depend on props and state.

Every approach below is a different answer to these three problems.

Family	How you write styles	Scoping	Runtime cost	Typical tools
Global CSS files	`.css` files, `className="card"`	Naming conventions (BEM)	None	Plain CSS, Sass
Inline styles	`style={{ color: 'red' }}`	Per element	Tiny	Built into React
CSS Modules	`.module.css`, `className={styles.card}`	Automatic, per file	None	Vite, Next.js, webpack
Utility-first CSS	`className="p-4 rounded-xl bg-white"`	Nothing to scope — classes are single-purpose	None	**Tailwind CSS**, UnoCSS
CSS-in-JS	Styles in JS (`styled.div\`…\``)	Automatic, generated names	Runtime libs: yes; zero-runtime: none	styled-components, Emotion; vanilla-extract, StyleX, Panda

The same card, styled five ways (`code/gallery.html`, components in `code/cards.jsx`):

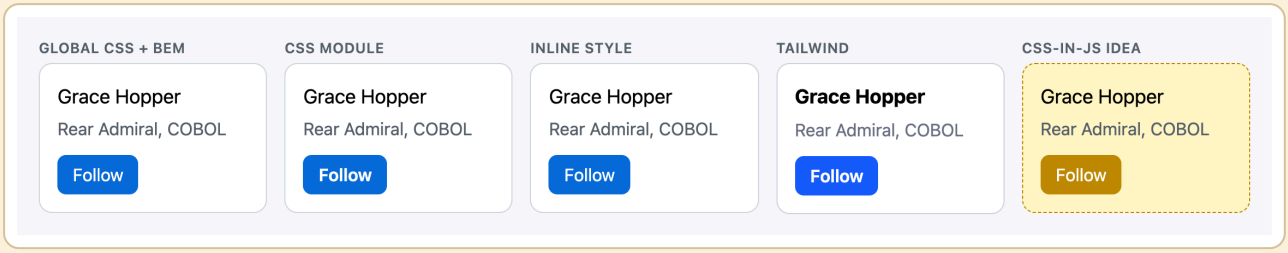


Figure 8.1 — One component, five styling approaches. The output is ordinary HTML + CSS in every case; they differ in how the CSS is authored, scoped and delivered. (The Tailwind heading uses an explicit `font-bold` — Tailwind's reset, "Preflight", removes default heading styles on the whole page, which is why the other headings look lighter than browser defaults.)

8.2 Plain CSS files

What it is

The oldest approach: write rules in a `.css` file and apply them with the **`className`** prop (JSX uses `className` because `class` is a reserved word in JavaScript — see Chapter 1). With a bundler such as Vite you can `import './Card.css'` from a component file; the bundler adds the file to the page's stylesheet.

```
// cards.jsx
import './global.css';
export function GlobalCssCard({ name, role }) {
  const [following, setFollowing] = useState(false);
  return (
    <div className="profile-card">
      <h3 className="profile-card__name">{name}</h3>
      <p className="profile-card__role">{role}</p>
      <button className={cx('profile-card__button', following && 'profile-card__button--following')}
              onClick={() => setFollowing(f => !f)}>{following ? 'Following' : 'Follow'}</button>
    </div>
  );
}
```

```css
/* global.css — BEM naming keeps selectors from colliding by convention only. */
.profile-card { border: 1px solid #d0d7de; border-radius: 12px; padding: 16px; background: #fff; }
.profile-card__name { margin: 0 0 4px; font-size: 18px; }
.profile-card__button:hover { background: #0550ae; }
.profile-card__button--following { background: #eaeef2; color: #24292f; }
```

How it works

1. `import './global.css'` is **not** JavaScript — it's a bundler feature. The bundler collects every imported CSS file into the page (a `<link>` in production, injected `<style>` in dev).
2. **Importing CSS in a component does not scope it.** Once loaded, the rules apply to the *whole page*, even to components that never imported the file.
3. To avoid collisions, teams use naming conventions such as **BEM** (Block__Element--Modifier): `profile-card` (block), `profile-card__name` (element), `profile-card__button--following` (modifier).

Trade-offs

✅ Strengths	❌ Weaknesses
Zero tooling, zero runtime, full CSS power (`:hover`, media/container queries, animations, nesting, `@layer`)	Global by default — scoping is only as good as your discipline
Easy for designers and CSS experts	Hard to know if a rule is still used; dead CSS accumulates
Browser caches the stylesheet separately from JS	Dynamic values need CSS variables or inline styles

Modern CSS removed much of the old pain: **native nesting**, **cascade layers** (`@layer` — decide which group of rules wins regardless of specificity) and **custom properties** all work in current browsers (HTML & CSS book, Chapter 13). Sass is still common but no longer necessary for variables or nesting.

React 19: stylesheets as components

React 19 can manage stylesheets for you: render `<link rel="stylesheet" href="/card.css" precedence="default" />` anywhere in the tree and React moves it into `<head>`, loads it once even if many components render it, orders it by `precedence`, and — inside a Suspense boundary — waits for it to load before revealing the content. This is mostly used by frameworks and libraries; in a Vite app you normally just `import` CSS.

TL;DR

`className` + CSS file. Imports are global — use a naming convention or move to CSS Modules.

8.3 Inline styles — the `style` prop

What it is

Every HTML element accepts a **`style` prop**: a JavaScript object whose keys are CSS properties in **camelCase** (`backgroundColor`, not `background-color`). React writes it to the element's `style` attribute. The double braces in `style={{ … }}` are a JSX expression (outer) containing an object literal (inner).

`code/01_inline_styles.jsx`:

```jsx
function ProgressBar({ percent, color = 'seagreen' }) {
  return (
    <div style={{ background: '#eee', borderRadius: 4, height: 8 }}>            {/* numbers -> px */}
      <div style={{ width: `${percent}%`, height: '100%', backgroundColor: color, borderRadius: 4 }}
/>
    </div>
  );
}

function Examples() {
  return (
    <>
      <ProgressBar percent={40} />
      <p style={{ lineHeight: 1.5, zIndex: 2, opacity: 0.8, flexGrow: 1 }}>unitless properties stay
unitless</p>
      <p style={{ '--accent': 'tomato', color: 'var(--accent)' }}>CSS custom property set inline</p>
      <p style={{ WebkitLineClamp: 2, msTransform: 'none' }}>vendor prefixes</p>
      <p style={{ ':hover': { color: 'red' }, '@media (max-width: 600px)': { display: 'none' } }}>no
pseudo-classes or media queries</p>
    </>
  );
}
```

Output (the elements' real `style` attributes; the first line is React's development warning):

```
Unsupported style property @media (max-width: 600px). Did you mean @media (maxWidth: 600px)?
<div style="background: rgb(238, 238, 238); border-radius: 4px; height: 8px;">
<div style="width: 40%; height: 100%; background-color: seagreen; border-radius: 4px;">
<p style="line-height: 1.5; z-index: 2; opacity: 0.8; flex-grow: 1;">
<p style="--accent: tomato; color: var(--accent);">
<p style="-webkit-line-clamp: 2;">
```

How it works — the rules the output shows

1. **Numbers get `px`** for length properties (`borderRadius: 4` → `4px`), but **unitless properties** (`lineHeight`, `zIndex`, `opacity`, `flexGrow`, …) stay plain numbers. For other units pass a string: `'50%'`, `'2rem'`.
2. **Custom properties** (`'--accent'`) are passed through unchanged — the cleanest way to feed a dynamic value into a stylesheet.
3. **Vendor prefixes** start with a capital (`WebkitLineClamp`), except `ms` (`msTransform`). (jsdom, like modern browsers, dropped the obsolete `-ms-transform`.)
4. **Pseudo-classes, pseudo-elements, media queries, keyframes are impossible**: a `style` attribute can't hold selectors or at-rules. The last `<p>` got no style at all, and React warned.

When to use it (and when not)

Use inline styles for	Don't use them for
Values computed at runtime: progress width, drag position, a user-chosen colour	Whole-component styling (no hover/focus/responsive; hard to override)
Passing a value to CSS: `style={{ '--progress': ${p}% }}` with the rest in a stylesheet	Anything a designer will want to theme
Quick prototypes	Large lists where every row repeats the same object (use a class)

Inline styles have the **highest specificity** of normal declarations, so a stylesheet can override them only with `!important` — another reason to keep them for truly dynamic values.

TL;DR

`style={{ camelCase: value }}`; numbers → px except unitless properties; no `:hover` or media queries. Best for dynamic values, ideally via CSS variables.

8.4 CSS Modules

What it is

A **CSS Module** is a CSS file (named `*.module.css`) whose class names are **local to the file that imports it**. The build tool renames every class to something unique and gives your JavaScript an object mapping the original names to the generated ones. You write normal CSS; collisions become impossible.

Supported out of the box by Vite, Next.js, Parcel, webpack's `css-loader` and esbuild — no library to install.

`code/Card.module.css`:

```
.card { border: 1px solid #d0d7de; border-radius: 12px; padding: 16px; background: #fff; }
.title { margin: 0 0 4px; font-size: 18px; }
.role { margin: 0 0 12px; color: #57606a; }
.button { font: inherit; padding: 6px 14px; border-radius: 8px; border: 0; background: #0969da; color:
#fff; cursor: pointer; }
.button:hover { background: #0550ae; }
.primary { composes: button; font-weight: 600; }       /* reuse another class */
:global(.sr-only) { position: absolute; width: 1px; height: 1px; overflow: hidden; clip: rect(0 0 0
0); } /* escape hatch */
```

Using it (`code/cards.jsx`):

```
import styles from './Card.module.css';
export function ModuleCard({ name, role }) {
  return (
    <div className={styles.card}>
      <h3 className={styles.title}>{name}</h3>
      <p className={styles.role}>{role}</p>
      <button className={styles.primary}>Follow</button>
    </div>
  );
}
```

What the bundler produces — `code/02_css_modules.mjs` runs esbuild on that file:

```
const result = await esbuild.build({
  stdin: { contents: `import styles from './Card.module.css'; console.log(JSON.stringify(styles, null,
1));`, resolveDir: '.', loader: 'js' },
  bundle: true, write: false, outdir: 'out', format: 'esm', logLevel: 'error',
});
// ... print the JS object and the emitted CSS
```

Output:

```
--- the JS object you get from `import styles from "./Card.module.css"` ---
{ card: "Card_card", title: "Card_title", role: "Card_role", button: "Card_button", primary:
"Card_button Card_primary" }
--- the CSS the bundler emits (renamed, so it cannot clash) ---
.Card_card {
  border: 1px solid #d0d7de;
  border-radius: 12px;
  padding: 16px;
  background: #fff;
}
.Card_title {
  margin: 0 0 4px;
  font-size: 18px;
}
... (role, button and button:hover renamed the same way)
.Card_primary {
  font-weight: 600;
}
.sr-only {
  position: absolute;
  ...
}
```

How it works

1. The tool parses the file and renames each class selector: `.card` → `.Card_card` (esbuild's scheme; Vite and webpack add a short hash, e.g. `_card_1x9ab_1`, so names are unique even across files with the same name).
2. `import styles from …` returns the mapping; `styles.card` is the generated string.
3. **`composes: button`** makes `styles.primary` equal *both* class names — `"Card_button Card_primary"` — reuse without duplicating rules.
4. **`:global(.sr-only)`** opts a selector out of renaming, for the rare global class you need.
5. Element selectors (`h3 { … }`) and IDs are *not* scoped — only class names — so keep module files to classes.

Trade-offs

✅	❌
Real CSS: hover, media/container queries, animations, nesting	Styles live in a second file (some like this, some don't)
Zero runtime, works with Server Components	Dynamic values still need CSS variables or inline styles
Unused-class detection with TypeScript plugins / linters	Class names with dashes need bracket access: `styles['is-active']` (or configure camelCase conversion)
Easy migration from plain CSS	Theming across modules relies on CSS variables (§8.8)

Common mistakes

- Naming the file `Card.css` (no `.module`) → nothing is scoped and `styles` is empty.
- Writing `className="card"` instead of `className={styles.card}` → no style applied (the real name is renamed).
- Referencing a class that doesn't exist → `styles.tittle` is `undefined` and React renders `class` without it — silently. TypeScript typings for modules catch this.

TL;DR

`*.module.css` + `styles.x`. Local class names, real CSS, no runtime. A safe default for teams that like writing CSS.

8.5 Composing class names from props

What it is

Real components choose classes based on props and state: a Button has a `variant`, a `size`, a `loading` state and maybe an extra `className` from its parent. Building that string by hand with `+` and ternaries is error-prone; the tiny **`clsx`** package (and its older sibling `classnames`) does it for you. `code/cx.js` is a 10-line version so you can see there's no magic:

```
// cx('a', cond && 'b', { c: true, d: false }, ['e', null]) -> 'a b c e'
export function cx(...args) {
  const out = [];
  for (const a of args) {
    if (!a) continue;                                  // false, null, undefined, 0, ''
    if (typeof a === 'string' || typeof a === 'number') out.push(a);
    else if (Array.isArray(a)) { const inner = cx(...a); if (inner) out.push(inner); }
    else if (typeof a === 'object') for (const [k, v] of Object.entries(a)) if (v) out.push(k);
  }
  return out.join(' ');
}
```

`code/03_class_names.jsx`:

```
function Button({ variant = 'primary', size = 'md', loading = false, className, ...rest }) {
  return (
    <button
      className={cx('btn', `btn--${variant}`, `btn--${size}`, { 'btn--loading': loading }, className)}
      disabled={loading || rest.disabled}
      {...rest}
    />
  );
}
// <Button>Save</Button>  <Button variant="danger" size="sm">Delete</Button>
// <Button loading>Uploading</Button>  <Button variant="ghost" className="ml-auto">Cancel</Button>
```

Output:

```
"btn active lg"
Save      class="btn btn--primary btn--md"
Delete    class="btn btn--danger btn--sm"
Uploading class="btn btn--primary btn--md btn--loading" disabled
Cancel    class="btn btn--ghost btn--md ml-auto"
concatenated: "btn false undefined"
```

The last line is the bug `clsx` prevents: naive concatenation leaks `"false"` and `"undefined"` into the DOM.

Patterns worth knowing

- **Always accept and merge a `className` prop** in reusable components, so parents can add spacing or layout (`ml-auto`) without forking the component.

- **Variant maps** beat nested ternaries: `const VARIANTS = { primary: '…', danger: '…' }` then `VARIANTS[variant]`. Libraries like **`cva`** (class-variance-authority) formalise this for Tailwind.
- **With CSS Modules**: `cx(styles.btn, styles[variant], loading && styles.loading)`.
- **With Tailwind**, conflicting utilities (`px-2` from the component, `px-4` from the parent) are *not* resolved by order in the string; use **`tailwind-merge`** (`twMerge(clsx(...))`) so the last one wins (§8.6).

In a real project: `npm install clsx` and `import { clsx } from 'clsx'` — the API above matches it for these cases.

TL;DR

Build class strings with `clsx`/`cx`; accept a `className` prop; use variant maps instead of ternary chains.

8.6 Tailwind CSS

What it is

Tailwind CSS is a **utility-first** CSS framework: instead of inventing class names (`.profile-card`) and writing rules for them, you compose many tiny single-purpose classes directly in your markup — `p-4` (padding), `rounded-xl`, `bg-white`, `text-gray-500`, `hover:bg-blue-700`. A build step scans your source files and generates CSS for **only the classes you actually use**. The current major version is **v4** (released January 2025; v4.3 at the time of writing), which is configured in CSS rather than a JavaScript config file.

The Tailwind card from Figure 8.1:

```
export function TailwindCard({ name, role }) {
  return (
    <div className="rounded-xl border border-gray-300 bg-white p-4">
      <h3 className="mb-1 text-lg font-bold">{name}</h3>
      <p className="mb-3 text-gray-500">{role}</p>
      <button className="rounded-lg bg-blue-600 px-3.5 py-1.5 font-semibold text-white hover:bg-blue-
700">Follow</button>
    </div>
  );
}
```

How it works

1. You add one line to your main CSS file: `@import "tailwindcss";` (it brings in the default **theme** — colours, spacing, fonts as CSS variables — **Preflight**, a CSS reset, and the **utilities** layer).
2. The build tool (the Vite plugin or the CLI) scans your project's source files for anything that looks like a class name. `@source "./path"` adds places it would not find by itself.
3. For each class it recognises, it generates one rule. Variants are prefixes: `hover:`, `focus-visible:`, `md:` (screen ≥ 48rem = 768px), `dark:`, `disabled:`, `group-hover:` …
4. Values come from the theme (`px-2` = 2 × `--spacing`), or you can use an **arbitrary value** in brackets: `w-[37px]`, `grid-cols-[1fr_2fr]`.

`code/05_tailwind_build.mjs` runs the real Tailwind CLI on a one-line component:

```
<span className="px-2 font-semibold hover:bg-blue-700 md:text-lg dark:text-white w-[37px]">new</span>
```

Output (the generated utilities — nothing else from Tailwind's thousands of possible classes):

```
@layer utilities {
  .w-\[37px\] {
    width: 37px;
  }
  .px-2 {
    padding-inline: calc(var(--spacing) * 2);
  }
  .font-semibold {
    --tw-font-weight: var(--font-weight-semibold);
    font-weight: var(--font-weight-semibold);
  }
  @media (hover: hover) {
    .hover\:bg-blue-700:hover {
      background-color: var(--color-blue-700);
    }
  }
  @media (width >= 48rem) {
    .md\:text-lg {
      font-size: var(--text-lg);
      line-height: var(--tw-leading, var(--text-lg--line-height));
    }
  }
  @media (prefers-color-scheme: dark) {
    .dark\:text-white {
      color: var(--color-white);
    }
  }
}
```

Notice: variants become ordinary CSS (media queries, `:hover`), `hover:` only applies on devices that can hover (v4 behaviour), and every value points at a theme variable — change `--color-blue-700` once and every use follows.

Setting it up (Vite — not run here)

```
npm install tailwindcss @tailwindcss/vite
```

```
// vite.config.js
import { defineConfig } from 'vite';
import react from '@vitejs/plugin-react';
import tailwindcss from '@tailwindcss/vite';
export default defineConfig({ plugins: [react(), tailwindcss()] });
```

```
/* src/index.css */
@import "tailwindcss";

@theme {                                  /* your design tokens -> new utilities */
  --color-brand: oklch(0.55 0.2 260);     /* enables bg-brand, text-brand, border-brand… */
  --font-display: "Inter", sans-serif;    /* enables font-display */
}
@custom-variant dark (&:where(.dark, .dark *));   /* optional: dark: follows a .dark class instead of
the OS */
```

(For this book the CLI does the same job: `tailwindcss -i tailwind.input.css -o tailwind.css` produced `code/tailwind.css` for the screenshot.)

Reusing styles: components, not `@apply`

Long class lists are repeated in one place only if you make a **component** (`<Button>`, `<Card>`) — that's the intended way to reuse Tailwind styles in React. `@apply` (copying utilities into a custom class) exists but brings back the naming and dead-CSS problems Tailwind was avoiding; use it sparingly (e.g. styling Markdown output you don't control).

Common mistakes

Mistake	Why it fails	Fix
`className={`bg-${color}-500`}`	The scanner reads source *text*; it never sees `bg-red-500`, so no CSS is generated	Map to complete class names: `{ red: 'bg-red-500', green: 'bg-green-500' }[color]`
`className="px-2 px-4"` expecting px-4 to win	Winner is decided by order *in the generated CSS*, not in the attribute	Don't pass conflicting classes; merge with `tailwind-merge`
Forgetting Preflight resets headings, lists, buttons	`<h1>` looks like body text	Style explicitly (`text-3xl font-bold`) — intended
Huge unreadable class strings	Hard to review	Extract components; order with the official Prettier plugin

Trade-offs

✅	❌
No naming, no switching files, no dead CSS (unused classes are never generated)	Markup gets long and noisy
Consistent design tokens (spacing and colour scales) out of the box	A new vocabulary to learn; team must agree to use it
Tiny production CSS that stops growing with the app	Dynamic values need arbitrary values or CSS variables
Zero runtime; works with Server Components	Styles are coupled to markup — harder to restyle a whole app by editing one stylesheet (use theme variables)

Real-world examples

Tailwind is the default in many starter kits (Next.js `create-next-app` offers it; shadcn/ui is built on it) and is used widely in product teams that value speed of iteration.

In the interview

> **30-second answer:** "Tailwind is utility-first: I compose small classes like `p-4 rounded-xl hover:bg-blue-700` in JSX, and the build scans my files and generates only the CSS I used, so there's no naming, no dead CSS and no runtime. Reuse happens through React components. The traps are dynamically-built class names, which the scanner can't see, and conflicting utilities, which need `tailwind-merge`. v4 configures the theme in CSS with `@theme`."

TL;DR

Utilities in JSX, CSS generated from what you use. Write complete class names, reuse via components, configure with `@theme`.

8.7 CSS-in-JS

What it is

CSS-in-JS means writing styles in JavaScript files, usually colocated with the component, often with access to props:

```
// styled-components / Emotion style (not run — not installed)
import styled from 'styled-components';
const Button = styled.button`
  padding: 6px 14px;
  border-radius: 8px;
  background: ${props => (props.$danger ? 'crimson' : '#0969da')};
  &:hover { filter: brightness(0.9); }
`;
<Button $danger>Delete</Button>
```

There are two very different kinds:

Kind	How it works	Examples
Runtime	In the browser, the library turns the template into CSS, hashes it into a class name, and injects a `<style>` tag while rendering	styled-components, Emotion
Zero-runtime (build-time)	A compiler extracts the styles into static `.css` files during the build; only class names remain in JS	vanilla-extract, Linaria, Panda CSS, StyleX (Meta)

How runtime CSS-in-JS works — a tiny version

`code/cards.jsx` contains a 5-line imitation, using a React 19 feature: a `<style>` element with `href` and `precedence` is **hoisted into `<head>` and de-duplicated** by React, however many components render it.

```
function css(strings) { /* hash the text into a class name, replace & with .className */ }
const cardStyle = css`& { border: 1px dashed #bf8700; border-radius: 12px; padding: 16px; background:
#fff8c5; }
  & h3 { margin: 0 0 4px; font-size: 18px; } & p { margin: 0 0 12px; color: #57606a; }
  & button { font: inherit; padding: 6px 14px; border-radius: 8px; border: 0; background: #bf8700;
color: #fff; }`;

export function CssInJsCard({ name, role }) {
  return (
    <div className={cardStyle.id}>
      <style href={cardStyle.id} precedence="medium">{cardStyle.text}</style>
      <h3>{name}</h3><p>{role}</p><button>Follow</button>
    </div>
  );
}
```

That is the yellow card in Figure 8.1. Real libraries add prop interpolation, theming, vendor prefixing and server-side extraction — and they must insert styles *before* layout effects read the DOM, which is why React has a dedicated Hook for library authors, `useInsertionEffect`.

Why the trend moved away from runtime CSS-in-JS

1. **Runtime cost**: serialising and hashing styles during render adds work to every render, and injecting new rules forces the browser to recalculate styles.

2. **Server Components** (Chapter 13): runtime libraries rely on React context and client-side rendering, so styled components must live in `'use client'` files.
3. **Streaming SSR** needs extra setup to collect styles per request.

In **March 2025 styled-components entered maintenance mode**; its maintainer advised against adopting it for new projects. Existing apps keep working, and Emotion remains widely used (e.g. inside MUI). New projects mostly choose CSS Modules, Tailwind, or a **zero-runtime** library that keeps the colocated, typed authoring style without the runtime.

Trade-offs

✅	❌
Styles next to the component; dynamic styles from props	Runtime libs: slower renders, bigger bundles, RSC friction
Automatic scoping; dead styles die with the component	Another abstraction to learn; debugging generated class names
Zero-runtime libs: type-safe tokens, static CSS output	Zero-runtime libs need build-tool plugins

TL;DR

Runtime CSS-in-JS (styled-components, Emotion) is convenient but costs render time and clashes with Server Components; zero-runtime tools (vanilla-extract, StyleX, Panda) or CSS Modules/Tailwind are the usual picks for new work.

8.8 Theming and dark mode

What it is

Theming means switching a whole set of design values — colours, radii, fonts — at once. The modern, framework-independent way is **CSS custom properties** (CSS variables) as **design tokens**: components only ever reference `var(--bg)`, `var(--accent)`; a theme is just a different set of values for those variables.

How it works

1. Define tokens on `:root`; override them under an attribute selector such as `[data-theme="dark"]`.
2. A small React **provider** stores the user's choice (`light` / `dark` / `system`), resolves `system` using the OS preference (the `prefers-color-scheme` media query), and writes the result to `<html data-theme="…">`.
3. CSS does the rest — no component re-renders are needed to recolour the page.
4. Save the choice in `localStorage`, and apply it with a tiny inline script **before** the page paints to avoid a **flash of the wrong theme**.
5. Set the CSS `color-scheme` property so browser-drawn parts (form controls, scrollbars) match.

`code/theme.css` (tokens):

```
:root {
  --bg: #ffffff; --surface: #f6f8fa; --text: #1f2328; --muted: #59636e;
  --border: #d0d7de; --accent: #0969da; --accent-text: #ffffff;
}
[data-theme="dark"] {
  --bg: #0d1117; --surface: #161b22; --text: #e6edf3; --muted: #9198a1;
  --border: #3d444d; --accent: #4493f8; --accent-text: #0d1117;
}
body  { background: var(--bg); color: var(--text); }
.panel { background: var(--surface); border: 1px solid var(--border); border-radius: 12px; padding:
16px; }
.cta  { background: var(--accent); color: var(--accent-text); }
```

`code/theme.jsx` (the provider — the OS setting is an external store, so it uses `useSyncExternalStore` from Chapter 7):

```
const ThemeContext = createContext(null);
const QUERY = '(prefers-color-scheme: dark)';

function subscribeSystem(cb) { const m = window.matchMedia(QUERY); m.addEventListener('change', cb);
return () => m.removeEventListener('change', cb); }
function useSystemDark() { return useSyncExternalStore(subscribeSystem, () =>
window.matchMedia(QUERY).matches, () => false); }

export function ThemeProvider({ children }) {
  const [choice, setChoice] = useState(() => localStorage.getItem('theme') ?? 'system'); // 'light' |
'dark' | 'system'
  const systemDark = useSystemDark();
  const resolved = choice === 'system' ? (systemDark ? 'dark' : 'light') : choice;

  useEffect(() => {                        // sync to the <html> element: CSS does the rest
    document.documentElement.dataset.theme = resolved;
    document.documentElement.style.colorScheme = resolved;   // native controls + scrollbars follow
    localStorage.setItem('theme', choice);
  }, [choice, resolved]);

  return <ThemeContext.Provider value={{ choice, resolved, setChoice }}>{children}
</ThemeContext.Provider>;
}

export function useTheme() {
  const ctx = useContext(ThemeContext);
  if (!ctx) throw new Error('useTheme must be used inside <ThemeProvider>');
  return ctx;
}
// ThemeSwitcher renders three role="radio" buttons: light / dark / system
```

`code/04_theme_provider.jsx` drives it with a fake OS setting:

Output:

```
first visit (OS light)     choice=system resolved=light | <html data-theme="light"> | saved=system
OS switches to dark        choice=system resolved=dark | <html data-theme="dark"> | saved=system
user picks "light"         choice=light resolved=light | <html data-theme="light"> | saved=light
OS changes again (ignored) choice=light resolved=light | <html data-theme="light"> | saved=light
reload                     choice=light resolved=light | <html data-theme="light"> | saved=light
outside provider -> useTheme must be used inside <ThemeProvider>
```

The same page in Chrome with the OS in light mode and in dark mode (`code/theme.html`, "system" selected):

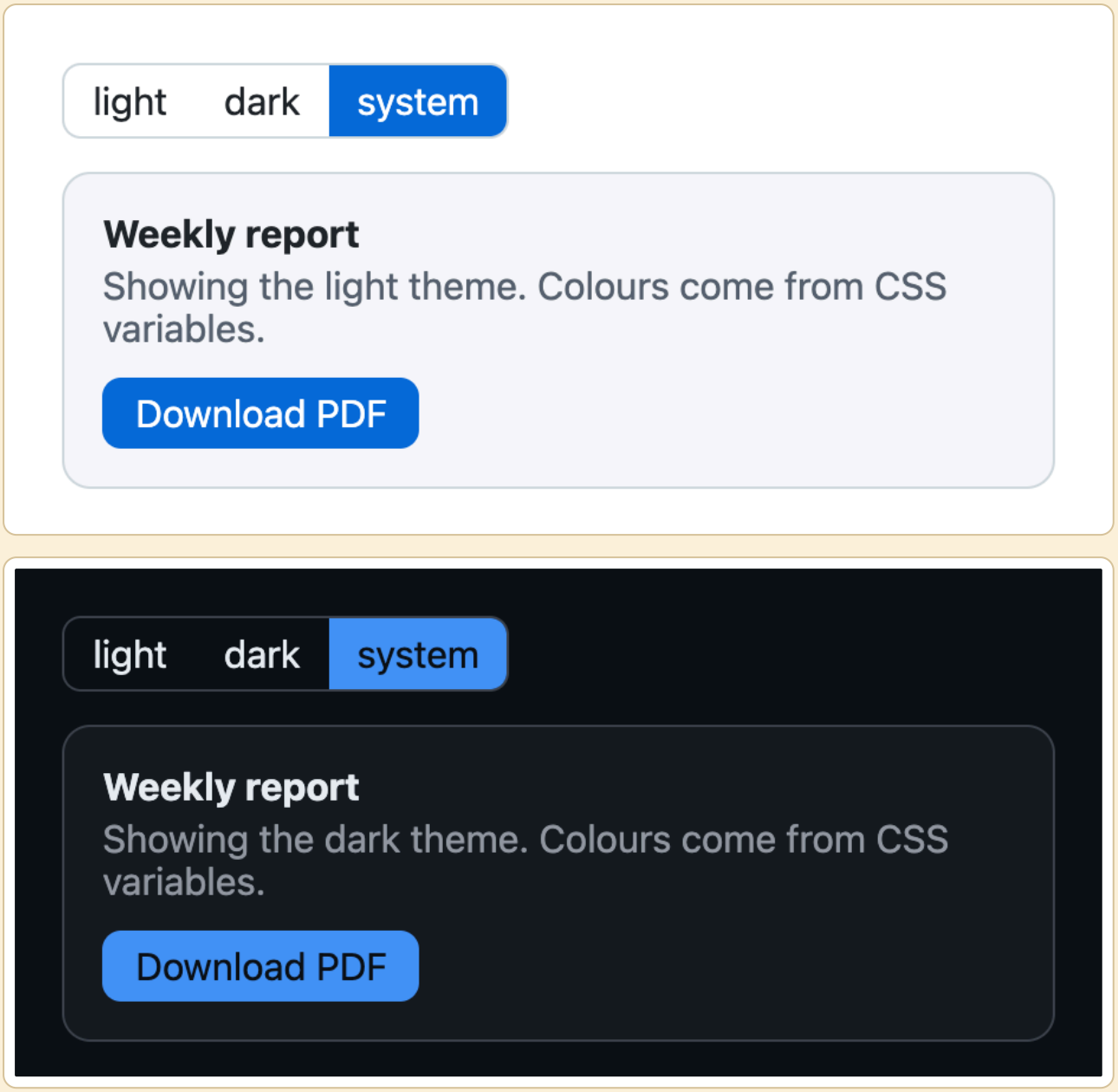


Figure 8.2 — One set of components, two token sets. Only the `data-theme` attribute on `<html>` differs.

Avoiding the flash

React runs after the HTML and CSS have been parsed, so if the theme is only applied in an Effect, a dark-mode user briefly sees the light page. `code/theme.html` fixes this with a blocking script in `<head>`:

```
<script>
  try {
    const saved = localStorage.getItem('theme') || 'system';
    const dark = saved === 'dark' || (saved === 'system' && matchMedia('(prefers-color-scheme: dark)').matches);
    document.documentElement.dataset.theme = dark ? 'dark' : 'light';
  } catch {}
</script>
```

Frameworks with SSR need the same trick (packages like `next-themes` inject it for you); a cookie lets the server render the right theme directly.

Alternatives and extras

- **CSS only**: if you don't need a manual toggle, `@media (prefers-color-scheme: dark) { :root { … } }` is enough — no JavaScript.
- **`light-dark()`**: with `color-scheme: light dark` set, `color: light-dark(#111, #eee)` picks a value per scheme in one declaration (Baseline since 2024).
- **Tailwind**: `dark:` variants follow the OS by default; `@custom-variant dark (&:where(.dark, .dark *))` or a `[data-theme=dark]` selector makes them follow your toggle.
- **Component libraries** expose a `ThemeProvider` that fills the same role (§8.9).
- **Why not pass colours through React context?** You can, but every theme change then re-renders every consumer; CSS variables recolour without rendering.

Common mistakes

- Hard-coded colours in components (`color: '#333'`) that don't respond to the theme — always use tokens.
- Reading `localStorage` during server rendering (it doesn't exist there) — read it on the client or use a cookie.
- Only inverting colours: dark themes also need adjusted shadows, borders and less saturated accents, and still must meet contrast ratios (WCAG 2.2: 4.5:1 for normal text).

TL;DR

Tokens as CSS variables, overridden by `[data-theme]`; a provider resolves light/dark/system and writes the attribute; a head script prevents the flash; `color-scheme` for native controls.

8.9 Component libraries

What it is

A **component library** gives you ready-made, accessible UI components — buttons, dialogs, menus, date pickers, tables — so you don't rebuild (and re-debug) them. Accessibility is the main reason to use one: a correct dropdown menu needs focus management, keyboard navigation and ARIA roles that take weeks to get right (see Chapter 14 and the HTML & CSS book's accessibility chapter).

Three kinds

Kind	What you get	Examples	Best when
Styled kits	Complete components with a design system and theming API	MUI (Material UI), Mantine, Chakra UI, Ant Design, React Bootstrap	Internal tools, admin panels, fast delivery, you accept their look
Headless (unstyled) primitives	Behaviour + accessibility, no styles — you bring CSS/Tailwind	Radix UI Primitives, React Aria (Adobe), Headless UI (Tailwind Labs), Base UI	A custom brand design that must still be accessible
Copy-in components	Source code copied into *your* repo (via a CLI), built on headless primitives + Tailwind	shadcn/ui	You want to own and edit the code, not depend on a package's API

How to choose

Question	Leans towards
Is there a designer with a custom design system?	Headless or copy-in
Do we need 50 components next week?	Styled kit
Are we using Tailwind?	shadcn/ui, Headless UI, Radix + Tailwind
Server Components / Next.js App Router?	Check the library's RSC guidance — many interactive components need `'use client'`
Bundle-size sensitive (public site)?	Headless + your CSS; import only what you use

Common mistakes

- Fighting a styled kit's design with overrides everywhere — pick headless instead.
- Mixing two styled kits (two resets, two themes, two button styles).
- Wrapping a library's component so thinly that you still leak its API everywhere — create your own `<Button>` that wraps it once, so you can swap later.

TL;DR

Styled kit for speed, headless for custom design with accessibility, copy-in (shadcn/ui) to own the code. Never hand-roll complex widgets without a reason.

8.10 Choosing an approach

Situation	Sensible default
New app, team likes utility classes and fast iteration	**Tailwind** + `clsx` / `tailwind-merge`, headless or shadcn/ui components
New app, team prefers writing CSS	**CSS Modules** + CSS variables for tokens
Content site with little interactivity	Plain CSS (with `@layer` and nesting) or CSS Modules
Existing styled-components/Emotion codebase	Keep it; consider zero-runtime or CSS Modules for new areas, especially if moving to Server Components
Design system shared across apps	Tokens as CSS variables + headless primitives; publish compiled CSS
Truly dynamic values (drag, progress, user colours)	Inline `style`, ideally setting a CSS variable

Whatever you choose, the rules that matter most are the same: **one approach per codebase**, **tokens in CSS variables**, **components as the unit of reuse**, and **accessibility first** — styles must never remove focus outlines without replacing them.

In the interview

> **30-second answer:** "React doesn't prescribe styling. Global CSS is simple but needs naming conventions; CSS Modules scope classes per file with zero runtime; Tailwind uses utility classes and generates only what I use; runtime CSS-in-JS like styled-components is convenient but adds render cost and doesn't fit Server Components, so zero-runtime tools are preferred now. Inline styles are for truly dynamic values. For theming I use CSS variables switched by a data attribute."

- *How do you handle dark mode?* — Tokens as CSS variables, `[data-theme=dark]` overrides, a provider for the toggle, a head script to avoid the flash, `color-scheme` for native controls.
- *CSS Modules vs Tailwind?* — Both scoped and zero-runtime; Modules keep CSS in CSS files with semantic names, Tailwind keeps styling in markup with a token scale. Team preference decides.
- *Why is `className` not `class`?* — JSX compiles to JavaScript, where `class` is a reserved word, and it matches the DOM property `element.className`.

Self-check

1. Does `import './Card.css'` scope the rules to `Card`? → No; imported CSS is global.
2. What does `style={{ zIndex: 2, width: 100 }}` produce? → `z-index: 2; width: 100px`.
3. Why won't `` `text-${size}` `` work in Tailwind? → The scanner only sees complete class names in source text.
4. What does `composes` do in a CSS Module? → Adds another class's generated name to this one.
5. How do you switch themes without re-rendering components? → Change CSS variable values via a `data-theme` attribute.

Chapter 8 TL;DR

Approach	Remember
Plain CSS	`className`; imports are global; BEM or layers for order
Inline `style`	camelCase object; numbers → px (except unitless); no `:hover`/media; for dynamic values
CSS Modules	`*.module.css`, `styles.x`; local names, `composes`, `:global`; zero runtime
Class composition	`clsx` / `cx`; accept `className`; variant maps
Tailwind v4	Utilities in JSX; only used classes generated; `@theme` tokens; no dynamic class names; `tailwind-merge` for conflicts
CSS-in-JS	Runtime (styled-components, Emotion) vs zero-runtime (vanilla-extract, StyleX, Panda); runtime is out of favour for new RSC apps
Theming	CSS variables + `data-theme`; provider for choice; head script against flash; `color-scheme`; `light-dark()`
Libraries	Styled kits vs headless vs copy-in (shadcn/ui); accessibility is the reason

Next: Chapter 9 — Routing and Data Fetching.